



United States
Attorney's Office
Southern District of Florida



Fraud Charges Filed Against 12 Defendants in Phase II of Operation Nightingale

Monday, September 15, 2025

For Immediate Release

U.S. Attorney's Office, Southern District of Florida

MIAMI – In the latest development of Operation Nightingale—a scheme that created an illegal licensing and employment shortcut for aspiring nurses—fraud-related charges have been filed against 12 defendants for their roles in selling fraudulent nursing diplomas and transcripts.

In Phase I of Operation Nightingale, 30 defendants were charged and convicted by plea or at trial in 2023.

According to court records, the defendants conspired to sell false nursing credentials—diplomas and transcripts fraudulently obtained from Florida-based nursing schools—to aspiring Registered Nurse (RN) and Licensed Nurse Practitioner/Vocational Nurse (LPN/VN) candidates. Purchasers of the bogus documents used them to qualify for the National Council Licensure Examination (NCLEX), commonly known as the nursing board exam. Candidates who passed the exam became eligible for licensure in various states, and once licensed, obtained employment as nurses across the United States.

The defendants, which include nursing school owners and employees, are charged with conspiracy to commit wire fraud. Their conduct involved multiple for-profit nursing schools in Florida, all of which have since closed. At one time, these schools were authorized to issue diplomas and transcripts to individuals pursuing RN and LPN/VN licensure. In total, the fraudulent schemes generated approximately 7,300 fake diplomas.

The charges highlight the purpose of a professional nursing licensure: protecting the public from harm by ensuring that only qualified and competent practitioners provide nursing care. Because nursing is a profession that, if practiced by unprepared or unqualified individuals, poses a serious risk to public health and safety, state boards of nursing establish standards for education, regulate licensure, and oversee compliance with training requirements.

The National Council of State Boards of Nursing (NCSBN), requires candidates seeking RN or LPN/VN licensure to graduate from a board-approved pre-licensure program and pass the NCLEX. The Nurse

Licensure Compact—adopted by 43 states, including Florida—further ensures that nurses meet consistent standards for safe practice.

In Florida, the Board of Nursing regulates pre-licensure programs and enforces curriculum requirements under the Nurse Practice Act. To protect patients and ensure safe nursing care, the Board requires that all applicants for licensure as an RN or LPN/VN graduate from an approved program, or its equivalent, and provide official transcripts or equivalent documentation before being permitted to sit for the licensure examination.

Florida's nursing programs must devote at least fifty percent of their curriculum to hands-on clinical training, in addition to academic coursework, for a practical nursing education program, an associate degree professional nursing program, or a professional diploma nursing education program.

Herline Lochard (Case No. 24-cr-60201-Singhal), 46, of Orange County, pleaded guilty to conspiracy to commit mail and wire fraud. Lochard served as the registered agent and/or manager of Center for Professional Training and Development Inc., located in Miami; Center for Professional Training Inc. located in North Miami; and Wheatland Institute Inc., located in Orlando. On July 31, Lochard was sentenced to 13 months in prison, followed by three years of supervised release.

Carleen Noreus (Case No. 25-cr-60039-Singhal), 51, of Broward County, is charged by indictment with conspiracy to commit wire fraud, wire fraud, conspiracy to commit money laundering, and money laundering. According to the indictment, Noreus served as the president of Carleen Home Health School, Inc., located in Plantation, and Vice President of Carleen Home Health School II, Inc., located in West Palm Beach.

From January 2019 through September 2022, Noreus and her co-conspirators solicited and recruited individuals seeking nursing credentials and health care employment. Noreus and others created and distributed fraudulent transcripts and diplomas that falsely represented the recipients had completed the necessary coursework and clinical training at Carleen Home Health School or Carleen Home Health School II. In reality, the individuals had not completed the required education or training.

Co-conspirators used these false and fraudulent documents to obtain nursing licenses in various states, including California, Pennsylvania, and Florida. Under the Nurse Licensure Compact, individuals who secured multi-state licenses through the fraud were also authorized to practice in other compact states without additional licensing.

The fraudulent credentials were then used to obtain nursing jobs and benefits from unwitting health care providers across the United States. These employers hired and paid salaries, wages, and benefits based on the fraudulent qualifications.

Noreus is set for trial beginning December 1 in Ft. Lauderdale.

Patrick Buchanan (Case No. 25-cr-60163-Damian), 40, of Broward County, pleaded guilty to conspiracy to commit wire fraud. Buchanan was the owner, registered agent, and manager of Sigma

Institute of Health Careers, Inc., located in Lauderhill. Sigma offered Practical Nursing and Associate of Science in Nursing programs.

Buchanan is scheduled to be sentenced on November 19.

Gilbert Hyppolite (Case No. 25-cr-60207-Dimitrouleas), 73, of Palm Beach County, is charged by indictment with conspiracy to commit wire fraud. Hyppolite was the owner of Techni-Pro Institute LLC, located in Boca Raton. Techni-Pro offered Practical Nursing, Associate of Science in Nursing, and Registered Nurse to Bachelor of Science in Nursing (RN to BSN) programs.

Irene Matthews (Case No. 25-cr-60209-Damian), 55, of Palm Beach County, is charged by indictment with conspiracy to commit wire fraud. Matthews was the registered agent and/or manager of Agape Academy of Sciences, LLC., located in Delray Beach. Agape offered Practical Nursing, Associate of Science in Nursing, and Bachelor of Science in Nursing programs.

Lemuel Pierre (Case No. 25-cr-60226-Damian), 56, of Broward County, is charged by indictment with conspiracy to commit wire fraud. Pierre was the owner of Med-Life Enterprise, Inc., located in Lauderdale Lakes, and founder of all Med-Life Institute locations. Med-Life Institute, doing business as Med-Life Institute Lauderdale Lakes, located in Lauderdale Lakes, offered Practical Nursing and Associate of Science in Nursing programs. Med-Life Institute, doing business as Med-Life Institute Kissimmee, located in Kissimmee, offered Practical Nursing and Associate of Science in Nursing programs. Med-Life Institute, doing business as Med-Life Institute Naples, located in Naples, offered Practical Nursing and Associate of Science in Nursing programs.

Joel Lubin (Case No. 25-cr-20391-Bloom), 51, of Miami-Dade County, is charged by information with conspiracy to commit wire fraud. Lubin was the registered agent and administrator of Ideal Professional Institute, Inc., located in Miami Gardens. Ideal offered Practical Nursing and Associate of Science in Nursing programs.

Jose Napoleon (Case No. 25-cr-60213-Martinez), 40, of Palm Beach County, is charged by information with conspiracy to commit wire fraud. Napoleon was the director of admissions for Azure College, Inc., located in Fort Lauderdale. Azure offered Practical Nursing, Associate of Science in Nursing, and Registered Nurse to Bachelor of Science in Nursing (RN to BSN) programs.

Victor Escalante Zerpa (Case No. 25-cr-60216-Smith), 68, of Miami-Dade County, is charged by information with conspiracy to commit wire fraud. Escalante Zerpa incorporated Academus University Corp, located in Coral Gables. Academus offered Practical Nursing, Associate of Science in Nursing, Registered Nurse to Bachelor of Science in Nursing (RN to BSN) programs.

Cleophat Tanis (Case No. 25-cr-60212-Dimitrouleas), 58, of Collier County, is charged by information with conspiracy to commit wire fraud. Tanis was the co-owner and operator of Med-Life Institute, doing business as Med-Life Institute Naples, located in Naples. Med-Life Naples offered Practical Nursing and Associate of Science in Nursing programs.

Lonnette Blair (Case No. 25-cr-60215-Becerra), 51, of Camden County, New Jersey, is charged by information with conspiracy to commit wire fraud. Blair was the Chief Academic Officer of Carleen Home Health School II, Inc. Carleen Home Health School II offered Associate of Science in Nursing and Bachelor of Science in Nursing programs.

Stephanie Dorisca (Case No. 25-cr-60214-Moore), 57, of Broward County, is charged by information with conspiracy to commit wire fraud. Dorisca was the Head of Nursing at Techni-Pro Institute LLC. Techni-Pro offered Practical Nursing, Associate of Science in Nursing, and Registered Nurse to Bachelor of Science in Nursing (RN to BSN) programs.

As to the wire fraud conspiracy charges, the defendants face a statutory maximum of 20 years.

U.S. Attorney Jason A. Reding Quiñones for the Southern District of Florida; Special Agent in Charge Brett D. Skiles of the FBI, Miami Field Office; and Acting Special Agent in Charge Isaac Bledsoe of the U.S. Department of Health and Human Services, Office of Inspector General, (HHS-OIG), Miami Regional Office, made the announcement.

FBI Miami and HHS-OIG Miami are investigating. Homeland Security Investigations Miami provided support.

Senior Litigation Counsel Christopher J. Clark is prosecuting the cases. Assistant U.S. Attorney Nicole Grosnoff is handling asset forfeiture.

If you have information to report regarding this case or any other case involving falsified medical degrees, please call the FBI hotline: (410) 277-6999.

An indictment is merely an accusation. All defendants are presumed innocent until proven guilty beyond a reasonable doubt in a court of law.

Related court documents and information may be found on the website of the District Court for the Southern District of Florida at www.flsd.uscourts.gov or on <http://pacer.flsd.uscourts.gov>.

###

Contact

Public Affairs Unit

U.S. Attorney's Office

Southern District of Florida

USAFLS.News@usdoj.gov

Updated September 15, 2025

Related Content

PRESS RELEASE

Cuban National Convicted of Unlawfully Obtaining US Citizenship After Concealing Healthcare Fraud Scheme

A federal jury has convicted a Cuban national of obtaining U.S. citizenship after she concealed her involvement in a multi-million-dollar healthcare fraud conspiracy during the naturalization process.

August 12, 2026

PRESS RELEASE

Healthcare Executive and Telemarketing Company Owner Sentenced to Prison for Exploiting Elderly Medicare Advantage Beneficiaries in \$35 Million Fraud Scheme

Two South Florida men, a healthcare executive and a telemarketing company owner, have been sentenced to federal prison for their roles in a scheme that resulted in the submission of...

July 30, 2026

National Health Care Fraud Takedown Results in 455 Defendants Charged in Connection with Over \$6.5 Billion in Alleged Fraud

Today, United States Attorney Jason A. Reding Quiñones for the Southern District of Florida announced criminal charges against 12 defendants in connection with alleged schemes to defraud Medicare, Medicaid, the...

June 25, 2026



Southern District of Florida

Main Office:

